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Leigh A. Leslie; Katherine Grady

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Changes in Mothers' Social Networks and Social Support Following Divorce

LEIGH A. LESLIE
The University of Maryland

KATHERINE GRADY*
Yale University School of Medicine

Although a mother's adjustment to divorce appears to be related to the support provided by her social network, it is unclear which network characteristics are associated with the provision of support. The present study examines this question while exploring how both network characteristics and support may change in the months and years immediately following a divorce. Thirty-eight mothers were interviewed following divorces, and again one year later, concerning the structural and interactional characteristics of their social networks and the support available to them. Results indicated that characteristics associated with the support a mother receives may differ from the characteristics associated with how satisfied she feels with her network. In addition, in the year following divorce, social networks become more homogeneous and allow for greater support as they become denser and more kin-filled. These findings are discussed in light of mothers' needs as they attempt to adjust to their new identities as divorced, single parents.

The increasing prominence of divorce in our society has been accompanied by an increasing concern with identifying factors that may affect individuals' adjustment to the life changes brought about by divorce. This concern has been more pronounced for women than men since they typically become the heads of single-parent families (U.S. Bureau of the Census, 1980) and have been found to experience adjustment problems for longer periods of time following divorce (Hetherington, Cox and Cox, 1977). One line of inquiry into postdivorce adjustment has focused on the role of supportive social relationships in

mediating the stress of divorce. Though various aspects of the concept of social support have been highlighted at different points, the general focus has been the presence of relationships that provide emotional, material, and instrumental or physical assistance (e.g., Jackson, Fischer and Jones, 1977; Pilisuk and Parks, 1980). In general, this body of research suggests that social support is related to adjustment following divorce, with mothers who have supportive relationships experiencing less stress (Raschke, 1977), being more effective parents (Colletta, 1979), and making better transitions in self-identity (Kohen, 1981) than divorced mothers who receive low levels of support.

Given this connection between the level of support available to a woman following divorce and how she copes with the problems presented by divorce, a critical subsequent question emerges: "What type of social network, or constellation of social relationships is most capable of providing this needed social support following divorce?" Though the question is only beginning to be investigated empirically, theoretical discussions have maintained that networks in which the members know one another (i.e., dense networks)

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Department of Family and Community Development,
The University of Maryland, College Park, MD 20742.

*Department of Psychiatry, Yale University School of Medicine, New Haven, CT 06519.

would be better equipped to provide support since members could communicate with each other and share responsibility for assisting the individual in need (Mitchell, 1969; Weiss, 1974). Such dense networks often may contain a large number of kin since kin will be more likely to know and interact with one another than will network members from diverse settings. The few existing empirical investigations indicate that divorced women do tend to turn primarily to their families for help—be it financial, emotional, or material (Anspach, 1976; Colletta, 1979). Interestingly however, some evidence suggests that it may be women in less dense, less kin-filled networks who show better adjustment following divorce (Wilcox, 1981). Though the availability of a tightly knit, supportive group of people may initially sound like the most desirable situation for a recently divorced woman, it is possible that a diverse, loosely knit network would provide a wider range of alternatives and information as a woman tries to restructure her life.

As the number of divorced mothers continues to increase, questions concerning what types of networks are capable of providing mothers with needed support are certainly worthy of additional investigation. To be of maximum benefit, such investigations should address two relatively overlooked issues in this area of study. First, investigations of network characteristics to date have focused largely on the structural characteristics of social networks. Structural characteristics commonly refer to the demographic and quantitative aspects of the network, such as number of members, sex and marital status of members, and number of kin in the network. In considering the supportiveness of a network, it seems that attention also should be given to such subjective, qualitative aspects of one's social relationships as feelings of closeness, affection, and similarity. Given that a divorced mother's assessment of the support—particularly emotional support—available to her is largely subjective, a better understanding of how supported she feels may be gained by looking at her more subjective evaluations of her network.

Second, social networks have tended to be viewed, operationally if not theoretically, as static structural and interactional arrangements. That is, little attention has been given to the fact that not only do networks vary in their organization but both the organization and how one feels about the relationships can change over time.

Exceptions to this pattern do exist. First, using data collected in interviews with women who had been divorced from 4 months to 20 years, McLanahan, Wedemeyer and Adelberg (1981) pro-

posed that the social networks of divorced women could be grouped into three types: family of origin, extended, and conjugal. These network types varied not only in membership and structure (i.e., who was included and how relationships were organized) but in the types of support they provided. While introducing the important conceptual premise that social networks may vary on a number of structural and interpersonal dimensions, thus affecting their capacity to provide different types of support, this research stopped short of incorporating the idea that an individual's network type, and hence her level of support, may vary over time. A second work taking a more dynamic approach to networks was that of Wilcox (1981), who utilized retrospective data to look at change in the composition of women's social networks from pre- to postdivorce. Comparing a group of women whose adjustment was defined as successful with a group whose adjustment was unsuccessful, Wilcox reported that women with less change or disruption in their networks following divorce were better adjusted than those who had experienced a great deal of turnover in the members of their social networks.

Still no attention has been given either to change that can be expected to occur in women's social networks in the months and years immediately following divorce or to the fluctuation that may occur in the social support available to them as a result of these changes. Changes in employment, residence, child care, and other activities are often necessary following a divorce. As these occur individuals may be added to or dropped from one's sphere of social relationships. As Wilcox (1981) so aptly pointed out, not until researchers begin to look at the temporal changes in individuals' social networks and the support they provide will we begin to understand what role relationships with others play as individuals strive to adjust to stressful events in their lives.

The purpose of the present study is to begin to take just such a descriptive look at the social networks of recently divorced mothers. Questions are explored concerning how networks change in the year following divorce and the implications of these changes for the support a divorced mother receives. Specifically, this investigation examines three central questions. First, it looks at the structural and interactional characteristics of mothers' social networks and the support available to these women immediately following their divorces. Questions are asked concerning the density of the network, the presence of kin or divorced individuals in the networks, and other characteristics that may relate to the type of support a network can offer. Second, the study examines the relationship

between the characteristics of one's network and the types of support available immediately following divorce. Third, we focus on the degree of stability or change in the network in the year following divorce, with particular attention given to the relationship between the initial characteristics of one's network and subsequent change. For example, are mothers with dense, kin-filled networks more likely to restructure their social relationships than are mothers with friend- or neighbor-dominated networks? In addition, we consider the differences that exist in relationships dropped from one's network and relationships added to one's network in the year following divorce. That is, do recently divorced mothers restructure their social networks following divorce to more adequately meet their needs as single adults and heads of their households? Finally, we compare the characteristics of divorced mothers' social networks and the support that these networks provide one year after divorce with the composition of the network and support available immediately following divorce.

METHOD

Participants

The names of recently divorced mothers were selected at random from court records in a northeastern city. Women selected from the court records for inclusion in the study had been granted divorce within the three months prior to the first data collection and had been granted custody of their children. Each woman was contacted by a letter and follow-up phone call and was included in the study only if she fit the additional study criteria: separated for less than one year prior to divorce, able to be interviewed within three months of divorce, and not planning to remarry within three months.

An initial letter describing the study was sent to 196 recently divorced mothers. The letter indicated that the investigators would be making a follow-up phone call but asked women to return an enclosed form indicating interest, particularly if they were not able to be reached by phone. The investigators then attempted to reach these women by telephone to explain the study further. There were no phone listings for 77 of the women and unpublished (and, therefore, unavailable) listings for 15 of the women. Another 15 women had phone listings but were no longer at the number or were unable to be reached. Therefore, only 89 (45.4%) of the mothers could be contacted by phone. Of those women contacted by phone, 38 (42.7%) expressed interest and were interviewed, 21 (23.6%) expressed initial interest but were not

interviewed because they did not fit the study criteria, and 30 (33.7%) women indicated they were not interested in the study.

A second interview, similar to the first, was conducted 10 to 12 months later. Of the 38 women interviewed the first time, 30 (79%) were available for the second interview. Of those not included in the sample at Time 2, five had moved from the area and/or could not be located, one was hospitalized following a serious accident, and two were unwilling to participate in the second interview. Not all women moving from the area were dropped from the sample. At Time 1 participants were asked to provide a name and telephone number of someone who would know the participant's whereabouts if they were to move in the next year. Two participants who had moved between the two interviews were located through this procedure and were included in the sample at Time 2. Since each woman provided information on her 10 most important relationships, the number of relationships sampled at the first time of measurement was 380, while 300 relationships were studied one year later.

The women participating in this study, 8% of whom were black, ranged in age from 23 to 43, with an average age of 33.85. The average education level was one year of college (range: 9th grade to postgraduate work); the average income, including earnings and child support, was approximately \$13,900 (range: \$5,200 to \$35,000). These mothers had between one and six children; the average number being 2.32.

Measures

Descriptive measures of each respondent's social network were collected as part of a larger study of mothers' adjustment to divorce. The information germane to this study was obtained through a social relationship questionnaire developed by the authors and modeled after those used by Cochran, Bronfenbrenner and Cross (1981) and Blieszner (1982). Participants were asked to identify 10 people who were important to them. Each respondent then answered a series of questions on her relationships with each person including such things as general demographic data, how they met, activities they shared, frequency of contact, and her feelings for the other person.

The decision to inquire about a fixed number of relationships was based on a desire to obtain an extensive amount of information on respondents' social relationships. Although this decision limits consideration of network size, it allows for more detailed characterization of the individuals with whom a recently divorced mother is most likely to be involved. For women with large networks, pro-

viding information on all their relationships would be an extremely time-consuming task. Thus, it was decided that 10 relationships were a manageable number for data collection and would still be sufficient to characterize these women's social networks. The social relationship questionnaire allowed for the collection of data in each of the three areas of interest described below.

Structural network characteristics. Structural characteristics are those that have to do with the composition and organization of one's social network. Three demographic variables were operationalized by calculating the percentage of individuals in a network who were relatives, the percentage who were divorced, and percentage who were female. Other demographic characteristics assessed included the age of network members and how long network members had been known. How close network members lived to the respondent was assessed using a six-point scale ranging from "in my house" to "over 100 miles away." Density, or the extent to which the 10 people identified knew each other, was expressed as the number of actual connections, or people who knew each other, over the number of possible connections. The amount of turnover in network membership between the two times of measurement was used as an indicator of the stability of one's social network following divorce. Stability was operationalized as the percentage of people listed in the network at both times of measurement.

Interactional network characteristics. Interactional characteristics have to do with the qualitative aspects of one's social relationships, such as the emotional tone of relationships or the patterns of interaction. The participants' frequency of contact with their networks was obtained by asking, "How often are you in contact with each person?" The eight response options ranged from "daily" to "less than once a year." The responses were averaged across the 10 network members to obtain an overall rating of interaction with the network.

The participants' emotional involvement in their networks, referred to as strength of ties, was assessed by averaging the responses to the statements, "It would be very hard for me to get along without this person" and "I am very close to this person." These questions were answered using a seven-point Likert scale of "strongly agree" to "strongly disagree." Again, the mean of the responses for the 10 network members was used as an index of the emotional strength of the network.

The extent to which participants perceived a similarity between themselves and members of

their networks was assessed by averaging the responses to the statements, "This person has interests that are similar to mine" and "This person has attitudes, beliefs, and values that are similar to mine." A seven-point Likert scale of "strongly agree" to "strongly disagree" was used. The network measure of similarity was the mean of the 10 relationship similarity scores.

Participants' satisfaction with their social networks was assessed by averaging the 10 responses to the question, "All things considered, how satisfied are you with your relationship with each person—with the time you spend together, the things you do, and so forth?" The question was answered using a seven-point Likert scale ranging from "not at all satisfied" to "completely satisfied."

Network support. The types of support provided by social relationships have often been grouped along three lines: (a) instrumental, or providing services such as running errands; (b) material, or providing goods and financial assistance; and (c) emotional, or showing concern and respect and giving encouragement or affection. Respondents were asked to indicate how often each network member provided each of these types of support. Instrumental support from a network member was assessed by averaging responses to two questions: "How often does this person run an errand or do a favor for you?" and "How often does this person share new information or facts with you?" Material support was assessed by averaging responses to the questions, "How often does this person give you an object or material thing?" and "How often does this person give you cash, a check, or a money order?" Finally, emotional support was assessed with these two questions: "How often does this person praise you or show you respect?" and "How often does this person give you affection or make you feel likable?" The nine response options ranged from "daily" to "never." Network support in each category was determined by averaging the support scores across the 10 people in the network. Similarly, overall support was determined by adding the three types of network support provided by each person and averaging these scores across the 10 network members.

RESULTS

Prior to addressing questions concerning the structure and supportiveness of divorced mothers' social networks, *t* tests for independent samples were computed on all relevant structural and interactional network characteristics and network support, comparing the group of mothers who participated in the study at both times of measure-

ment with those mothers who dropped out of the sample following the first data collection. Though the two groups did not differ on the majority of network characteristics, two significant differences were found. Participants dropping out of the sample had, at Time 1, significantly more divorced people in their networks, $t(36) = 2.49$, $p < .05$; and had known their network members for a significantly shorter period of time, $t(36) = 2.54$, $p < .05$, than had the group completing both interviews. Given these differences, it was decided that all further analysis would be done only on the sample of participants who remained in the study for both occasions of data collection.

Network Characteristics at Time 1

The first task of this study was to describe the social networks of divorced mothers shortly after their divorces (see Table 1). Kin was definitely the primary source from which these mothers drew their network members, with 32% ($n = 96$) of all identified network members being kin. Only 2 mothers listed no relatives in their networks, 8 mothers listed one or two relatives, 14 mothers listed three or four relatives, and 6 mothers listed five or more relatives in their networks. The workplace was the second most common source of significant relationships, with 21% ($n = 61$) of the 300 individuals having been met originally through work. Second, on the average these women's networks were made up of more married than divorced individuals. The average number of married and remarried people in the networks was 5.2 ($M = 4.1$ for married only once), while an average of only 2.6 network members were di-

vorced or separated. This figure of approximately one-fourth of the network members being divorced is, however, somewhat reflective of the distribution of divorced individuals in our society. It should be noted that the participants' networks seemed to vary greatly in this area, with 27% of these women having four or more divorced individuals in the network and another 27% having no, or only one, divorced network member.

The networks were made up primarily of women, with 63% ($n = 188$) of the identified network members being female. Almost one-half ($n = 14$) of the participants had networks that were 70% or more female.

Network members were largely people the participants had known for a long time. Only one participant had a network in which she had known network members, on the average, for less than five years. On the other hand, approximately one-third of the participants ($n = 11$) had networks in which the network members had been known for an average of over 15 years.

Although for the most part participants had known network members for long periods of time, these network members varied in how near they lived to the mothers. While 73% ($n = 22$) of the mothers reported that at least one network member lived in her neighborhood, none reported more than three. Similarly, though 10 mothers reported that the majority of their networks lived in the same town or city, there were 17 mothers for whom the majority of their networks lived out of town. Thus, it seems that a number of women did not have a network that was immediately physically available. However, all of the women reported that at least one-half of their networks lived within 50 miles of them, suggesting that none of the sample was totally physically isolated from people who were important to them.

Finally, these divorced mothers' networks appeared to be fairly dense, with 80% of the participants ($n = 24$) stating that network members knew, on an average, at least one-half of the other members. In addition, over one-third of the participants ($n = 12$) said that network members knew, on an average, at least 8 of the other network members.

In terms of the interactional characteristics of participants' networks, it appears that these women had networks characterized by feelings of emotional closeness with people whom they perceived as similar to themselves. Fifty-three percent of the women ($n = 16$) had an average closeness score of 5 or greater (on a scale of 1 to 7), while 40% ($n = 12$) had an equally high similarity score. Overall, participants were satisfied with their relationships, with 63% ($n = 19$) having an

TABLE 1. CHARACTERISTICS OF DIVORCED MOTHERS NETWORKS, TIME 1 ($n = 30$)

Characteristic	<i>M</i>	Range	<i>SD</i>
Structural:			
Number of kin	3.2	0-7	1.6
Number of women	6.3	4-9	1.1
Number of divorced network members	2.6	0-6	1.6
Average age	36.2	25.9-49.5	6.2
Average years known	13.9	2.6-20.3	3.9
Location of residence	3.3	1.9-4.6	.6
Density of network	6.6	2-10	2.1
Interactional:			
Satisfaction	5.3	3.4-7.0	.9
Emotional closeness	4.8	2.1-6.5	.9
Similarity	4.7	3.0-5.8	.7
Frequency of contact	6.4	4.3-7.8	.9
Support:			
Overall support	4.5	1.2-6.5	.9
Instrumental support	5.1	1.8-7.8	1.5
Material support	2.9	0-4.4	.8
Emotional support	5.5	1.8-7.6	1.2

average satisfaction score of 5 or greater. In terms of involvement with the network, it appears that these women interacted frequently with network members. Participants reported that they were in contact with each member of their network, on the average, more than once a week. In fact, 70% of the women ($n = 21$) stated that they were in contact with at least one-half of their network members several times a week or more.

Finally, these mothers appeared to have networks that were emotionally available and willing to help when needed. Participants reported that on the average they received some type of emotional support such as affection or praise from each member of their networks between one and several times a month ($M = 5.5$, $SD = 1.2$). Similarly, each network member appeared to provide instrumental support such as running errands, babysitting, and sharing information on a monthly basis ($M = 5.1$, $SD = 1.1$). On the other hand, financial or material support was more rarely given, occurring on the average about once a year ($M = 2.9$, $SD = .8$).

In summary, then, these divorced mothers appeared to have very close-knit networks following their divorces. Their networks were composed primarily of kin and coworkers whom they had known for long periods of time and who lived, for the most part, relatively close by. Furthermore, these were networks in which many members knew one another. Mothers appeared relatively satisfied with these relationships and interacted frequently and regularly with members of their networks. In terms of the support available to these recently divorced mothers, it seems that network members helped instrumentally and emotionally but that financial assistance occurred less often.

Relationship Between Network Characteristics and Support Received

The next series of analyses explores the links between the structural and interactional characteristics of a network and the support it provides. Though the primary focus is understanding how support is related to various network characteristics, attention is given to the association among network characteristics as they clarify the nature of supportive networks. Pearson product-moment correlations were computed between all structural and interactional characteristics and are presented in Table 2.

Looking first at the association between the structure of a network and the level of support it provides, the most noteworthy factor appears to be the number of kin in the network. The presence of kin is correlated with instrumental aid, and

with the overall level of support, one receives. In addition, a statistically nonsignificant trend suggests that greater numbers of kin in the network are associated with higher levels of material support ($r = .24$, $p = .09$). The only other structural characteristics that seems to be related to the overall amount of support available to these mothers is the presence of network members living nearby. Mothers whose network members lived close by were more likely to receive assistance in general, but particularly as it related to daily help with errands and tasks. It should be noted that significant relationships exist between the density of these mothers' networks and the degree to which they provide instrumental and material support. However, when the three categories of support are combined into an overall index, the relationship does not reach statistical significance. In light of past theoretical arguments, the lack of association between network density and provision of emotional support is as striking as the positive association between density and the provision of tangible goods and services. These findings suggest that, though communication among network members may facilitate the network's ability to respond to the tangible and physical needs of the divorced mother, it does not automatically increase the network's ability to respond to her more subjective, personal needs.

Correlations among the structural variables associated with support indicate that dense networks tend to have high numbers of kin and people who live nearby. There is no connection, however, between the number of kin in the network and having network members who live close to the mother. Thus, divorced mothers appear to receive the majority of their support from two separate groups, their relatives and their neighbors.

Looking next at the association between how these mothers interact with their networks and the support they receive, it is clear that frequency of interaction is the variable most strongly associated with each type of support a mother receives. It is not surprising that mothers report receiving more assistance from people with whom they spend more time. Of all the interactional variables considered here, this is the least subjective in that, though it may be a reflection of the quality of the relationship, it can be observed. Of the more subjective variables, only satisfaction with network relationships is associated with support.

In tying these findings in with the structural variables associated with support, frequency of interaction is significantly correlated with how close network members live but not with the number of kin in the network. Interestingly, satisfaction with the network, though correlated with

TABLE 2. CORRELATIONS OF NETWORK CHARACTERISTICS FOLLOWING DIVORCE

Network Variables	No. Kin	No. Women	No. Divorced	Age	Years Known	Place of Residence ^a	Density	Satisfaction	Closeness	Similarity	Frequency of Contact	Overall Support	Instrumental Support	Material Support	Emotional Support
Structural:															
No. of kin	1.00														
No. of women	-.32*	1.00													
No. of divorced	-.13	-.13	1.00												
Age	.14	.13	.08	1.00											
Years known	.62**	.08	-.13	.55**	1.00										
Place of residence	-.28	.12	.00	.52**	.24	1.00									
Density	.43**	-.06	.14	-.20	.27	-.33**	1.00								
Interactional:															
Satisfaction	.23	-.04	-.36*	.47**	.42**	.24	-.11	1.00							
Emotional closeness	.21	.20	-.06	.20	.35*	.09	-.09	.44**	1.00						
Similarity	.07	.35*	.18	.33*	.33*	.35*	-.20	.42**	.71**	1.00					
Frequency of contact	.13	-.12	-.21	-.11	-.11	-.50**	.09	.06	.08	-.10	1.00				
Support:															
Overall support	.31*	-.03	-.07	.16	.05	-.30*	.27	.30*	.13	-.02	.49**	1.00			
Instrumental support	.33*	-.14	-.22	-.01	-.04	-.36*	.30*	.24	.06	-.08	.49**	.92**	1.00		
Material support	.24	.03	.11	.30*	.14	-.15	.33*	.25	-.04	.17	.27	.84**	.75**	1.00	
Emotional support	.21	.03	-.02	.15	.02	-.26	.11	.29	.27	.14	.48**	.71**	.69**	.55**	1.00

^aScoring for residence is reversed; the closer one lives, the lower the residence score.* $p < .05$.** $p < .01$.

support, is not related to the number of kin in the network, how close network members live, or how frequently mothers are in contact with network members. The factors associated with a recently divorced woman being satisfied with her network are, it seems, somewhat different factors from those associated with her receiving support from the network. The network characteristics associated with mothers' satisfaction have to do with how strong the emotional ties are, similarity in values and attitudes, and how long mothers and network members have known each other. That is, though present-oriented interaction is connected with support, the subjective evaluation of satisfaction seems to be tied to the presence of relationships with a significant history of interaction and concern.

It is interesting to note, however, that a negative relationship exists between the number of divorced individuals in the network and how generally satisfied a mother is with her network relationships. One might speculate that it would be helpful to have people in the network who have shared a similarly painful experience and could empathize; yet, this does not appear to be the case. In fact, the presence of divorced family and friends is not in any way related to the support or assistance a mother is likely to receive.

Changes in Network Membership

The third question to be considered here is, "To what extent does network membership change in the year following a divorce?" A frequency count of the number of new people appearing on the list of important relationships one year after the mothers' divorces revealed that all but one participant had some change in network composition. The average number of new relationships was three ($M = 3.37$, $SD = 1.5$), with the mode being four ($n = 11$). One-fifth of the sample ($n = 6$) had at least a 50% turnover in their network lists. Correlations between network stability and the structural, interactional, and support characteristics of the network at Time 1 indicate four important variables in predicting change in network membership. Stability in the network seems to be related to the number of kin in the network ($r = .55$, $p < .01$), the density of the network ($r = .57$, $p < .01$), the length of time network members had been known ($r = .45$, $p < .01$), and the amount of overall support the mothers received from the network following their divorces ($r = .33$, $p < .05$). In fact, when used as predictors of how stable mothers' networks were, these four variables accounted for 47% of the variance (see Table 3), with density alone accounting for 33% of the variance. It ap-

TABLE 3. REGRESSION ANALYSIS FOR NETWORK STABILITY

Predictor Variables	Multiple <i>R</i>	<i>R</i> ²	Beta	<i>F</i>
Density	.57	.33	.39	5.59*
Number of kin	.66	.43	.20	.99
Years known	.68	.46	.21	1.25
Overall support	.69	.47	.15	.87

Note: Overall $F = 5.63^{**}$; $df = 4.25$.

* $p < .01$.

pears, then, that some changes in network membership are likely in the year following divorce, but comparatively few individuals experience extensive turnover in their significant relationships. Furthermore, the best predictor of the stability of one's network is the extent to which network members know one another.

With the patterns of network change more clearly illuminated, differences between network relationships that maintain their importance and those where importance declines can now be explored. Two questions are considered here: (a) To what extent do relationships dropped from the network in the year following divorce differ from those relationships that remain important? (b) What are the characteristics of relationships that mothers add to their networks following a divorce? To answer the first question, the 300 relationships identified by mothers at Time 1 were grouped according to whether or not they were again listed in the network one year later. Then, t tests for independent samples were computed between these two groups on all Time 1 structural and interactional relationship characteristics. In contrast to previous analyses, these tests used each relationship as a unit of analysis instead of using network indices formed by summing across relationships. Results indicated that those network members who remained important to mothers were significantly different from other network members in several ways. Individuals remaining in the network, compared with those who were dropped, had been known for longer periods of time ($t[298] = 3.86$, $p < .01$), lived closer to mothers ($t[298] = -2.84$, $p < .01$), knew more network members ($t[298] = 6.50$, $p < .01$), and were more likely to be related to the mothers ($t[298] = 6.81$, $p < .01$). Relationships with these individuals also were rated more satisfying ($t[298] = 2.18$, $p < .05$) and emotionally stronger ($t[298] = 5.71$, $p < .01$) than were relationships that were dropped. Finally, those individuals remaining in the network were in touch with the mothers more often ($t[298] = 3.80$, $p < .01$) and provided them with higher levels of instrumental ($t[298] = 5.36$, $p < .01$), material

($t[298] = 6.80, p < .01$), and emotional ($t[298] = 5.39, p < .01$) support. Thus, it seems that relationships that decrease in importance are different from those that remain central in terms of structure, patterns of interaction, and the support they provide.

The second question, concerning relationships that became important to mothers in the year following divorce, was also approached by comparing the group of relationships dropped from the network list at Time 2 with the group of relationships added. Network relationships that became important or increased in their importance following divorce differed from relationships dropped in three significant ways. These people knew more network members ($t[206] = 3.61, p < .01$), were more likely to be related to mothers ($t[206] = 4.75, p < .01$), and gave more support to mothers ($t[206] = 3.53, p < .05$). In fact, those added to the network provided more support in each category: instrumental ($t[206] = 2.49, p < .05$), material ($t[206] = 2.62, p < .01$), and emotional ($t[206] = 3.30, p < .01$). Thus, over the course of one year, it seems that mothers' networks became more homogeneous as the presence of supportive kin who knew one another became even more prevalent.

Finally, in comparing mothers' networks just after their divorces and one year later, the most striking finding is that the networks look very similar at these two times. Although some shifting of social relationships has occurred, the basic picture of the overall network has changed in only a few ways. First, the number of kin in the network has increased ($t[29] = 1.94, p = .06$). One year following divorce, 12 of the women had five or more kin in their networks, whereas a year before only 6 had a similar number of kin. In addition, 39% ($n = 118$) of the 300 network members identified by mothers at the second time of measurement were kin, as compared with a year earlier when only 32% ($n = 96$) had been kin.

Likewise, one year after their divorces, the density of the networks increased ($t[29] = 3.08, p < .01$). Over one-half ($n = 17$) of these women had networks in which members knew, on the average, 80% or more of the other members. Approximately one-third of the networks were this dense a year earlier.

Finally, the denser, more kin-filled networks appeared to provide greater emotional support ($t[29] = 2.02, p < .05$) than did the networks that existed immediately after the divorces. While network members were providing emotional support between once and several times a month following the divorce ($M = 5.49, SD = 2.3$), one year later mothers were receiving emotional sup-

port from each network member on an average of several times a month ($M = 5.90, SD = .99$).

DISCUSSION

A substantial literature has documented the positive effect of supportive, satisfying relationships immediately following divorce. It is less clear, however, how changes occur in the structure of one's network in the years following a divorce and how these changes may affect the support available to the recently divorced individual or his or her satisfaction with network relationships. The present study attempted to describe the characteristics of supportive networks for divorced mothers and to examine changes in network structure, interaction, and support over time. It should be noted that the sample of networks ($n = 30$), though not the sample of relationships ($n = 300$), was relatively small, so the data should be viewed as preliminary indicators upon which more extensive work can be based.

In the present study, the social networks of divorced mothers were largely found to be close-knit units composed of kin and friends who lived relatively close by. The support available to these mothers was tied largely to the number of kin in the network, current patterns of interaction, and mothers' satisfaction with their social relationships. On the other hand, mothers' satisfaction with network relationships was influenced more strongly by the presence of old friends and individuals the mothers perceived as similar to themselves. In looking at how stable network membership was in the year following divorce, it seems that, though almost all the mothers experienced some changes, those with supportive, dense networks with an extensive history together were the least likely to experience turnover. In fact, those individuals who were added to the network or increased in importance in the year following a divorce were quite likely to resemble the network members already present (i.e., were kin, knew one another, and were supportive of mothers). Thus, the divorced mothers in this study seemed to homogenize their networks following divorce in the direction of increased density and family membership.

When considered in light of previous research findings on social network composition and adjustment to divorce, these data suggest a curious pattern. First, we know that kin are likely to be the most supportive following divorce, a fact reestablished with this data. Yet Wilcox (1982) found that women in less dense, less kin-filled networks were better adjusted following divorce. Similarly, Berman and Turk (1981) reported that, for both men and women, successful strategies for

coping with divorce had to do with developing a sense of autonomy and expanding one's learning and realm of social activities. In this study, however, we find mothers moving to denser, more kin-filled networks in the year after their divorces. It is not clear to what extent individuals self-selected out of a network, mothers dropped people who were not supportive, or kin just seemed to "rally around" and thus increase their importance in the mothers' time of need. However, the net effect is the same. Instead of experiencing more flexible norms and expectations from diversifying their networks at a time when they are trying to establish a new identity, mothers in this study appear to be surrounding themselves with just those people who may have difficulty offering them new models or options for coping. Although factors such as similarity and emotional closeness were associated here with satisfaction with social relationships, these were apparently not the factors that affected mothers' addition of new people to their networks. In a time of stress it seems that people who knew one another and could mobilize to be responsive and helpful were the most highly valued. This idea is reinforced further by the lack of association between the number of divorced individuals in a mother's network and the support available to her, as well as the negative relationship between the presence of divorced network members and satisfaction. One might assume that other people who had experienced divorce could best assist recently divorced mothers in the transitions they must make. Yet, if they do provide models or alternatives for coping, mothers in this sample did not, in the year following their divorces, seem to put much import on them.

Two perspectives can be applied to these findings. First, it is appealing to hypothesize that mothers need loose-knit networks which provide them with a variety of experiences and options. Yet, when a woman is trying to adjust to being a single parent and supporting a family, new experiences and flexible norms may be somewhat of a luxury. Help in managing the various responsibilities she now faces may be her primary concern. Second, it may be that one year postdivorce is not a long enough period of time to observe the movement of divorced mothers toward exploration of options regarding their personal and social identities. As Hetherington, Cox and Cox (1979) have pointed out, improvement in coping—in terms of both social relationships and parenting skills—is typically seen around 18 months after a divorce. Thus, the mothers in this study may not have reached a point in the adjustment process where they might find a dense network limiting. Regardless of which perspective is taken, the long-term

implication is that if divorced mothers at some time need to move away from a dense, kin-filled network in order to address personal needs and further the adjustment and growth process, this increased reliance on family following divorce may impede such movement.

This initial attempt to look at change in networks following divorce does suggest that restructuring occurs and that, in turn, the ability of social networks to support mothers during this stressful period increases. It also suggests that the full impact of these network changes may not be clear until over one year has elapsed. Continued attention to changes in network structure and functioning following the stressful life event of divorce appears warranted. Based on the findings of this study, particular emphasis should be given to the extent to which increased reliance on kin support in the year following divorce affects later adjustment.

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